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Guidelines for

Responsible Use of AI

in the Doctoral Dissertation

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Doctoral Programs — ESU

**Advisory
Framework
Version 1.0**

9 Core Topics

**for Doctoral
Students**

Why This Document Exists

Setting the stage for this class and the year ahead

The Context

AI is everywhere — and it's not going away.

As doctoral candidates, you're entering the most intellectually demanding phase of your academic journey.

These guidelines exist not to police you — but to **protect your scholarly identity** and give you a shared framework with your chairs and committees.

What This Document Is

- ✓ An advisory framework — not a rulebook
- ✓ Aligned with PASSHE & federal guidance (U.S. Dept of Ed, 2023)
- ✓ Built around 9 core topics covering the full dissertation process
- ✓ A resource for you, your chair, and your committee
- ✓ A living document — it will evolve as AI does

You Own This Work.

Regardless of what tools you use, you must be able to explain, defend, and claim every idea, argument, and conclusion in your dissertation.

EXPLAIN

DEFEND

CLAIM

The Core Principle

"The dissertation is both a scholarly product and a formative process."

All tools may support your work — but they cannot replace it.

Scholarly Ownership

You own and can defend every idea

Independent Inquiry

Your reasoning, synthesis, judgment

Intellectual Accountability

You can explain your work to your committee

Topic 1 — Purpose & Scope

What these guidelines cover and who they apply to

These guidelines apply to all dissertation-related activities: topic development, proposal writing, literature review, data analysis, drafting, revision, and oral defense preparation.

01

Clarify appropriate and inappropriate AI uses

02

Support ethical and informed decision-making

03

Provide faculty a shared evaluative framework

04

Promote consistency, transparency, and trust

Topic 2 — Scholarly Ownership

Your name is on it. Your thinking must be in it.



Responsibility for all ideas, arguments, interpretations, and conclusions rests entirely with you — regardless of whether AI tools were used.



AI USE IS APPROPRIATE WHEN...



Supports organization and clarity



Improves efficiency without replacing reasoning



Helps refine or edit your own ideas



Assists formatting or grammar



AI USE IS INAPPROPRIATE WHEN...



Generates substantive scholarly content



Produces arguments you can't independently defend



Obscures your intellectual authorship



Replaces your analysis, synthesis, or voice

Process Support vs. Product Substitution

✓ PROCESS SUPPORT

AI supports HOW you work

- Organizing notes, outlines, research materials
- Identifying areas that need clarification
- Grammar, formatting, and style support
- Prompting reflection you independently evaluate

✗ PRODUCT SUBSTITUTION

AI determines WHAT you argue

- Generating original arguments or conclusions
- Synthesizing literature instead of you
- Producing text you cannot independently defend
- Shaping your scholarly voice without engagement



Writing is Cognitive Work

Why your dissertation writing cannot be outsourced to AI

"In doctoral education, writing is a central cognitive activity through which scholarly thinking develops."

— ESU AI Dissertation Guidelines, Topic 3

Drafting

Not just transcribing thoughts — it's the act of forming and testing them

Revising

Clarifies arguments and reveals gaps in your reasoning

Defending

You must be able to explain every sentence to your committee

Topics 4 & 5 — Verify Everything, Disclose Openly

Topic 4 — Verification

AI-generated content is unverified until YOU confirm it.

- Independently verify all factual assertions
- Confirm the existence and relevance of cited sources
- Assess potential bias, incompleteness, or misrepresentation
- Ensure appropriate scholarly context
- AI surfaces info — you validate it

Topic 5 — Transparency

Disclosure is professional practice, not confession.

- Discuss AI use with your chair and committee
- Describe the nature and purpose of AI use when relevant
- Clarify which aspects involved AI-supported processes
- Retain documentation to explain AI use if questions arise
- No surprise disclosures — ongoing dialogue

Topics 6 & 7 — Ethics, Bias & Data Privacy

Topic 6 — Ethics & Bias

AI tools carry the biases of their training data.

- ⚠ AI may reflect historical or systemic biases
- ⚠ May privilege dominant perspectives
- ⚠ Can generate confident but inaccurate outputs
- ⚠ Evaluate for bias, exclusion, or distortion
- ⚠ Maintain awareness of how AI shapes framing



Topic 7 — Data Privacy

Protect research participants and sensitive data.

- Never enter identifiable or protected data into AI tools
- Follow IRB requirements and research protocols
- Understand the data-handling practices of AI platforms
- Consult your chair when uncertain about data use
- De-identified / synthetic data: OK with care

Topics 8 & 9 — Evolving Tech & Shared Responsibility



Topic 8 — Evolving Technologies

This document is a living framework. AI capabilities are changing rapidly, and these guidelines will adapt. When in doubt, your dissertation chair is your first resource — not the internet.

Topic 9 — Who Is Responsible for What

Doctoral Candidates

- Ensure independent scholarly judgment
- Verify accuracy of all content
- Communicate transparently with chair
- Defend all work, including AI-assisted

Dissertation Chairs & Committees

- Guide ethical scholarly practices
- Clarify discipline-specific expectations
- Evaluate reasoning, originality, rigor
- Engage in dialogue on AI questions

Institutional Advisors (AIRC)

- Provide policy & ethical guidance
- Support consistency across programs
- Monitor emerging AI trends and risks
- Recommend updates as needed

What This Means for You — Right Now

As you begin Chapters 1–3

You are beginning the most formative phase of your doctoral journey. The habits you build now will shape how you work for the rest of your career.

1

Talk to your chair first

When uncertain about AI use on any part of your dissertation — ask before you act.

2

Use AI as a thinking partner, not a ghostwriter

Brainstorm with it, organize with it, clean up grammar — but the intellectual work is yours.

3

Verify everything AI gives you

Citations, facts, summaries — treat all AI output as unverified until you confirm it.

4

Document as you go

Keep notes on how you used AI tools so you can discuss it transparently if asked.



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Questions & Conversation

The full guidelines document is your reference for the year ahead. It covers 9 topics from scholarly ownership and process support, to verification, transparency, bias, data privacy, and shared responsibility.

When uncertain about a specific AI use — your dissertation chair is always your first point of contact.

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9 Topics Covered

Purpose & Scope

Ownership

Process vs. Product

Verification

Transparency

Ethics & Bias

Data Privacy

Evolving Tech

Roles & Responsibility